Even if it possesses the technology necessary to micromanage people's lives, a democratic government leaves as much room as possible for people to make their own choices. A common misconception is that in a democracy everything is decided by majority vote. In fact, in a democracy as little as possible is decided centrally, and only the relatively few decisions that must be made centrally should reflect the will of the majority. In a democracy, if 99 per cent of people want to dress in a particular way and worship a particular god, the remaining 1 per cent should still be free to dress and worship differently.

Of course, if the central government doesn't intervene at all in people's lives, and doesn't provide them with basic services like security, it isn't a democracy; it is anarchy. In all democracies the centre raises taxes and maintains an army, and in most modern democracies it also provides at least some level of health care, education and welfare. But any intervention in people's lives demands an explanation. In the absence of a compelling reason, a democratic government should leave people to their own devices.

Another crucial characteristic of democracies is that they assume everyone is fallible. Therefore, while democracies give the centre the authority to make some vital decisions, they also maintain strong mechanisms that can challenge the central authority. To paraphrase President James Madison, since humans are fallible, a government is necessary, but since government too is fallible, it needs mechanisms to expose and correct its errors, such as holding regular elections, protecting the freedom of the press and separating the executive, legislative and judicial branches of government.

Consequently, while a dictatorship is about one central information hub dictating everything, a democracy is an ongoing conversation between diverse information nodes. The nodes often influence one another, but in most matters they are not obliged to reach a consensus. Individuals, corporations and communities can continue to think and behave in different ways. There are, of course, cases when everyone must behave the same and diversity cannot be tolerated. For example, when in 2002–3 Americans disagreed about whether to invade Iraq, everyone ultimately had to abide by a single decision. It was unacceptable that some Americans would maintain a private peace with Saddam Hussein while others declared war. Whether good or bad, the decision to invade Iraq committed every American citizen. So also when initiating national infrastructure projects or defining criminal